

phones, so that we can listen to audio on the move, which is hardly optimum listening—the sights and sounds of the environment will cause you to never know the difference between the audio quality of your Discman and MP3 player.

2.1.3 LAME

lame.sourceforge.net / www.mp3dev.org

LAME, a recursive acronym for “LAME Ain’t an MP3 Encoder,” is perhaps the most popular of audio codecs. It is used with the MP3 container, and is what the majority of software applications use for ripping CDs. If you’ve ever taken some of your CDs, popped them into the PC and used the “Rip” option that’s available in players such as Winamp, or conversion software such as dBpowerAMP, you have used the LAME encoder!

LAME uses a lossy algorithm to compress audio, mainly for streaming purposes and portable music players. With MP3s becoming the de-facto standard of compressed digital audio, and portable music players being renamed “MP3” players, LAME has gained even more popularity. This can also be attributed to the fact that it’s open source, as compared to Fraunhofer’s l3enc MP3 encoder patent.

If you’ve read this far, and are a little confused about MP3 and all the mentions of patented and open source MP3 encoders, join the club! There’s so much grey area in this weird battle, no-one seems to know what about MP3 is patented, and what isn’t. Let’s digress for a bit to tell you a little story of patent stupidity.

In September 2006, at the IFA trade fair in Berlin, SanDisk’s booth was raided by the German police, and all their MP3 players were confiscated: a case filed by the firm Sisvel, which sells MP3 playability licenses (which, in turn, it licensed from Philips) to companies that make MP3 players, claimed that SanDisk owed it money for failure to buy a license to incorporate the MP3 playback feature in their devices. On the same day that SanDisk filed an appeal, and won, Sisvel got the public prosecutor to file a case in